

HOME ALONE

THE OLD FEEL ISOLATED AND UNCARED FOR AS INDIA GREYS. AN AGONISING LIFE CRISIS GRIPS FAMILIES AS THE YOUNGER GENERATION STRUGGLES TO LOOK AFTER AGEING PARENTS. NEW ADJUSTMENTS AND EQUATIONS ARE BEING FORGED. BUT THE DISQUIET REMAINS.

By Damayanti Datta

Do I know you?" asks her dad. They are sitting at a table in a brasserie. She is nursing a margarita, her dad's got a mint chocolate milk—a Sunday ritual ever since her mother died two years ago, the flat in Mumbai was sold off and dad was moved to Bangalore at age 83. But after a fall last summer, her once-workaholic father seems to have lost his bearings. He has trouble recognising faces, even his own in a mirror—a brain disorder. "Dad, it's me, your daughter," she thinks she can reason him out of this. But his eyes—clouded by cataracts—stare forlornly back. He looks sad, confused. All around them there are happy faces—the messy, charming chaos of family life—men and women lounging, a toddler crying. She sets the drink down and stares blindly at the back of his beloved, weathered hands.

27 million elderly are ill, need specialised care.